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The Mouth of Hell

Shah Shuja's fourth attempt at recapturing his throne – what would be remembered by British historians as the opening of the First Afghan War – got off to as chaotic a start as any of its predecessors.

The plan was, in principle, a good one. First there would be a ceremonial send-off at Ferozepur in the Punjab, attended by all three of the signatories of the Tripartite Alliance. Then, as with Shah Shuja's previous expedition five years earlier, Afghanistan would be invaded by two routes. One army, led by the Shah's eldest son, the Crown Prince Timur, assisted by Colonel Wade and a regiment of Punjabi Muslims supplied by Ranjit Singh, would move north through Peshawar up the Khyber Pass and hence towards Jalalabad. The other – much the larger of the two – would nominally be led by Shah Shuja under the watch of Macnaghten, assisted by troops from the Company's Bengal and Bombay armies. This force would loop south around the Punjab, as Ranjit had now banned British soldiers from marching through his lands. It would then head through the Bolan Pass to attack southern Afghanistan below Kandahar before heading on to Ghazni. Both forces would converge on Kabul to restore Shuja to his throne in the Bala Hisar. At the same time, Shah Shuja's many eager allies in Afghanistan would rise up in his favour, expelling the 'usurper', Dost Mohammad. 'Almost every chief of note should begin to tender his homage